to have him out, not I nor even the Prince, or the Shah himself, can prevent their doing so. One of their complaints was that he had got all the best lands, either into his own hands or those of his relations. I asked the bearer of the letter why, when I was in the village they did not state these things to me. "Because" said he with an air of vexation "day by day we were expecting you to call a meeting of the inhabitants as you did last year, when we should have been able to declare our grievances but at last you went away without doing so." I felt that the rebuke was just, and promised to let them have an election after they had finished with their harvest. This has satisfied them for the present. I give the term election to this business because I have no other word for it but they do not meet and vote. The thing is arranged amongst themselves, they meet and talk the matter over and whenever a large majority is in favor of one man the govt people can not resist their wish, if they did the people would stand upon their rights, and would not pay taxes. If, as not infrequently happens, the govt man is a tyrant he might catch, fine, and punish, two or three of the leaders in such a movement, but he would get no good by this, and all men of sense find it best to let them have their own way. When the parties in a village are pretty equally divided the govt man may choose for himself whichever of the candidates he likes best. When there is a large majority in favor of one man he is obliged to yield or he will ruin his own village. I was once complaining to two or three of the priests of the village of the people being such drunken, fighting, riotous rascals, and asked whether they were always so. They laughed and said when the village was Houssein Khan's he took no pains about it and left it almost entirely to the management of his people, the consequence was that scarcely a week passed without fights and drunken squabbles, and some of the inhabitants who were joined by the soldiers and they fought with Houssein Khan's agent and his people, which ended in the defeat of the latter who was driven into a tower where they placed a guard over him and refused to let him come out, until he had paid a fine of twenty tomauns! The story is almost too good to be true, particularly as they say the Khan took no notice of the matter. —

We have not yet seen the new comet[77] which I see is mentioned in the newspapers. — Did you see Capt Warner's experiment? I translated a long account of it for the Prince. —

[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *7, Tabreez, October 1844*

You will be glad to hear that Dr Wolff, who so nobly undertook to go to Bokhara and endeavour to release Stoddard, Conolly and others who were supposed to be in there in slavery, has returned to Meshed and is daily expected at

[77] Faye's comet.

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